

Space3

Space3 Manifesto:

Life is about community, art, and adventure.

For us, the youth of today, many spaces are restricted by commercialization. Capitalism demands we spend cash to experience adventure, so we become recluses in our boxes – bound by the walls of our rooms and our screens. Innately we yearn for nature as our ancestors had for millions of years. However, we suffer as the first generation to subsist for entire seasons in concrete jungles, never seeing natural forms, separated from the earth. Our mission is to bring back free adventure.

Third spaces are dying. The youth are left in a post-covid era, no shopping malls or common spaces to congregate¹. Space3 is a manifestation of our urge to bring back third spaces, to satiate our dreams of physical adventure in this dystopian concrete hellscape.

Abandoned spaces are a symptom of late-stage capitalism and poor management of resources in the name of quick profit. Neglected for years, even decades, decommissioned structures are everywhere. **Space3 puts capitalist wastelands on a map, a receptacle of reclamation, a gateway to a gatekept community.**

¹Ephrat Livni, "Where Have All the 'Third Places' Gone?," *New York Times*, February 28, 2025, <https://www.nytimes.com/2025/02/28/business/third-place-meaning-starbucks.html>.

Locative Media and The Role of the Artist:

As artists we were inspired by site-specific locative media in the course reading list. Locative media is an artform that connects experiences or narratives directly to particular places, making the location itself part of the meaning. Artists working with locative media often focus on exposing hidden technological infrastructures and critiquing systems of mapping and surveillance².

For UrbanX, graffiti is essential in the locative media landscape to open up spaces and change relationships to site, as well as acting as a political protest for disused spaces. **Though this vandalism is controversial, it signals information about a site.** Graffiti acts as a location-based archive embedded in the site itself. It can mark the history of artists, explorers, and squatters. It can also be key in assessing the security risk of a site – abundance of graffiti indicates accessibility and low security, while clean walls may be a sign that a site is heavily patrolled or inaccessible. Further, it inherently communicates a political message about capitalist wastelands and landuse. In 2025 a skyscraper development project in Los Angeles ran out of funds mid-development and left the project abandoned for years. **Hundreds of graffiti artists protested the development in an organized stunt that covered all 49 stories of the two towers in tags**³. Space3 was inspired to create this project due to the artists we know who centre their practices around abandoned spaces, utilizing locative media.

We see the importance of locative art also through the lens of the role of the artist. We were inspired by artists such as Rick Lowe and Theaster Gates' who defined **the artist's ethics as a source of community benefit rather than vessels of gentrification and cultural capital**. Both of these artists purchased functionally abandoned structures and sustainably repaired them and made them

² Jonah Brucker-Cohen, "Locative Media Revisited," rhizome, March 26, 2014, <https://rhizome.org/editorial/2014/mar/26/locative-media-revisited/>.

³ Rodger Vincent, "Graffiti-Tarnished Towers in Downtown L.A. Remain in Limbo," *Los Angeles Times*, August 20, 2025, <https://www.latimes.com/business/story/2025-08-20/sale-of-graffiti-tarnished-towers-in-downtown-los-angeles-still-dragging-on>.

into community centers⁴⁵. The reclamation of spaces and utilization of abandoned urban space is key to Space3's purpose.

⁴ Reinhardt, K. (2015). Theaster Gates's Dorchester Projects in Chicago. *Journal of Urban History*, 41(2), 193-206.

⁵ Eureka Gilkey, "Commentary: Project Row Houses: Arts, Culture, and Collective Creative Action," *Journal of the Association for Consumer Research* 4, no. 4 (October 2019): 334-35, <https://doi.org/10.1086/705026>.

Interface:

The project consists of four pages: **Home, Map, Gallery, and About.**

When developing our communication framework we drew inspiration from Lev Manovich. As Manovich outlines, new media objects give us the unique ability to bridge the gap between machine language and humans which is what Space3 does; it makes complex hidden data visible and appealing. Databases inherently lack order or meaning, so it is up to us to allow exploration, translating unreadable databases into unique user experiences⁶.

Space3 attempts to create this bridge by **transforming the machine language of raw spatial data into a human centric accessible interface**. To achieve this, we use the **OpenStreetMap API**, a crowdsourced geographic database that allows users worldwide to contribute spatial information⁷. By filtering and interpreting this data through the OpenStreetMap API, Space3 generates an interactive map that identifies and pins abandoned buildings within a 5km radius of the user. When a location is selected a pop up appears with the available identifying information including coordinates, building name, number of floors, etc. The pop up also contains a button which allows you to redirect to Google Maps, streamlining navigation.

To encourage exploration outside of a user's immediate area the map also includes a search bar where users are able to search any city in the world for marked abandoned buildings. By curating spatial data, Space3 redistributes access to hidden urban landscapes.

"Maps are power and those who draw them provide access to the world." Philipp Ronnenberg (quoted in Jonah Brucker-Cohen)⁸.

In the Gallery page, the interface follows the theme of communication by introducing users to artists within the UrbanX community, it also functions as a platform that foregrounds and

⁶ Lev Manovich, "Database as a Genre of New Media," *AI & Society* 14, no. 2 (June 2000): 176-83, <https://doi.org/10.1007/bf01205448>.

⁷ Sarah (Tong) Zhang, "Using OpenStreetMap for Your Research: Leveraging a Massive Global Geographic Database That Emphasizes Local Knowledge," web log, *Radical Access: The SFU Scholarly Publishing Blog* (blog) (SFU, October 7, 2022), <https://www.lib.sfu.ca/help/publish/scholarly-publishing/radical-access/openstreetmap-your-research>.

⁸ Jonah Brucker-Cohen, "Locative Media Revisited," *rhizome*, March 26, 2014, <https://rhizome.org/editorial/2014/mar/26/locative-media-revisited/>.

promotes UrbanX artistic production. As users explore, initially concealed artist information is gradually revealed. On load the center frame of the gallery page is filled with a graffiti layer. But when the user hovers over the center frame, fragments of the different artworks are revealed beneath it. This intentional fragmentation hints at the artist's work but sustains a sense of incompleteness. This encourages users to click on the images to redirect themselves to the artist's individual Instagram pages where they're able to access the pieces in their entirety.

The design language was created as a blend of our aesthetics as artists. Unified by nostalgia for a time in our life without smartphones, the interface. The textural work was inspired by Sophia's aesthetic, while the colours were determined by Skyla's logo and Abhis photography.

Process & Challenges:

Some of the primary challenges were integrating code, communicating and unifying the styles, and learning the capabilities and limitations of each language. Skyla and Abhi created the home page, the map page, and the about page. Abhi primarily created the 3d rendered, photographic, and iconographic elements, and Skyla primarily created the logo, the API code, the integration/css styling, and the writing; however, these elements were still all collaborative. Sophia created the Gallery page and contributed to the stylistic language of the website, as well as the writing.

For Skyla, the API was one of the primary challenges. Initially trying the Google Places API for a week, she found no way to access permanently closed places without paying Google. Since this was essential for the website, she pivoted to a few APIs before finding OpenStreetMap. Finding this was key because it aligned with our mission of open source information and democratized maps from the course readings.

Skyla also found communication to be a challenge, finding it difficult to stay on the same page. Further, coordinating meetups and ensuring that the group stayed informed of project updates also posed a challenge, but she is proud of the group and how the outcome of the site is cohesive and operational.

Sophia encountered two key challenges when building the gallery page: the lack of a predefined architectural framework and constructing a non-rectilinear grid system. At the beginning of the coding process, she only had a vague visual direction. She did not consider the interaction design or relational hierarchy between elements nor did she define the language which would be mediating these interactions. This significantly reduced her efficiency as she had to make structural decisions iteratively. This also became a challenge when she came up with new conceptual directions which often demanded she override or restructure her entire system. This experience underscored the importance of establishing a clear architecture when approaching a complex project.

However, although she initially adopted an object oriented coding strategy as a response to the assignment she quickly realized

its invaluable ability to add clarity when navigating and altering an increasingly complex system.

Another issue Sophia faced was creating a grid that deviated from the conventional rectangular logic. In this case she aimed to create a grid that followed the geometry of a star. While attempting to create this she found that the only way she could visually mirror this effect was to create a larger grid and positioning image elements using a fixed position. However, this solution failed to be responsive to window resizing. She then experimented with creating a borderless collage of images that was visually clipped with a masking layer. The result was a series of oddly cut images but she actually enjoyed this result and felt this fractal/fragmented aesthetic added to the meaning of the project.

In creating the initial design language, we were inspired by our shared nostalgia from the time before the internet, when we were adventurous kids. We struggled to find a balance on how minimalistic the site should be, and we redesigned the map page numerous times. In the end, we landed on embodying early tech interfaces while simplifying the interface itself, only having elements appear when interacted with.

For Abhi and Skyla, working on the about, map, and initial pages posed challenges at times. Because of our design differences, the large amounts of code we were working with, and the stylistically dense content of each page, we started photoshopping each page to perfection before implementing it in code. This streamlined the process so that after the code style integration was debugged, it was completed. We found this allowed us to build a more complex system.

Though it was challenging to find middle ground at times, we are very proud of what we created. During this process, we learned a lot about each other's core aesthetics, which made us understand our own aesthetics on a deeper level. We also learned the importance of adding comments to our work, and over this project Abhi got better at leaving comments to Skyla to make integration easier and Skyla got better at communicating code limitations so Abhi could adapt his models.

After the product was almost complete, we showed it to our friends and watched them navigate the site, finding the smallest errors and issues and optimizing user flow and navigation, with Abhi changing photoshopped mockups and Skyla integrating them into code. We then repeated this cycle until we caught everything. The elements we changed were graphics for if the code throws API errors, adding white overlays that fade out so the user does not see the map load in, and changing button size and placement.

Unified by our passion for the project and excitement towards the possibilities, we were able to challenge each other and push ourselves to create the best product we possibly could.

Aspirations:

We don't claim to have premonitions but hope this tool is used to create guerilla gallery and community art spaces. Whether it provides a platform for impromptu raves, skateparks, or graffiti collages we hope that this tool democratizes spaces for creation and performance for the disenfranchised. We hope to aid the resistance and fight our capitalist overlords who demand privatisation and exclusivity. We the people choose to nationalize these unoccupied spaces. In doing so we ask people engaging with this tool with the ethos of **safety**, **reciprocity**, and **maintenance**. Let us not reduce ourselves to the wolves they expect us to be. Let us demonstrate that collectivism and democratization doesn't sow chaos but growth.

Community Input (Interviews:)

In developing the project, we formally and informally interviewed 3 artists who work with UrbanX landscapes and share a passion for exploring. **Kat** is a painter studying at Concordia who encapsulates the desolate fragmented structures in bright technicoloured acrylics. **Sophie** is a painter living in Kelowna, BC who paints sites and superimposes her own graffiti onto the paintings. **Nicholas** is a photographer and artist studying at Concordia.

Questions:

1. How did you get into UrbanX?
2. How do you usually discover spaces for urban exploring?
3. What drives you to continue to be interested in UrbanX?
4. What are your thoughts on having a map based website dedicated to mapping urban exploration spots?

Sophie:

1. I first got into urban exploring by finding an abandoned maison in the forest as I was taking a walk with my friend. I was 14, I had never seen such a thing before and instantly fell in love.
2. Most of the spots I visit are found organically, roaming around and finding a hidden gem unpromptedly. The second spot I visited was and still is the reason I do what I do today, as I witnessed the craziest light streaks coming through the windows of the building, from the infinite amount of spray paint particles filling the air. I always say I feel like it rewired my brain chemistry as I don't think I have ever been this stunned before.
3. My passion for abandoned buildings comes from my curiosity and the infinite amount of surprises that can be found in those places. I find endless beauty and inspiration in ruins, in concrete, in rust, in the light that reflects off weird puddles of unknown substances on their floors and the colorful masterpieces that ornate their walls. They are always a feast for the eyes, as there is always more to be noticed.
4. I like the idea of having a map based website for urban exploration as I have been looking for a reliable one forever. However, I do believe, like most people, that the spots have to be given into trusted hands as some places should be very carefully preserved.

Nicholas:

1. Partly from my liking for photography, and desire to explore and visit unusual sights, I enjoy seeing how elements of the past are left to decay, and seeing what remains. Most places are reclaimed by nature, or are scheduled for destruction, which incites me to go see and document them before they are gone. There is also an element of adrenaline associated to the dangers and the legality of visiting these places, some of which we pass by, or know of, but never get to really see. It is an activity that is fun to do with friends who share what I just mentioned.
2. Most places I've explored are places I've previously passed by, or known through friends. There have been cases of information exchanges with other urban explorers, but these are harder as people try to protect the sites from getting too much attention, or being lost to vandalism. I used to use an app called Abandoned World, in which people would pin and photograph abandoned places, for others to discover. I am also in the Urbex MTL server, where people often share media (coordinates or names are never shared in the server, only through dms if you establish connections with the members)
3. Photo/videography, the adventure and adrenaline, as an activity with friends, and experiencing these unusual sights which most people don't get to see.
4. It's a very cool concept, it's an interesting tool to find places in my opinion. However, I know that the general opinion of adept Urbex explorers is that it is best to make this information as least accessible as possible, the problem is that spots becoming known mostly brings negative effects for those who visit or know them. Highly concurred urbex spots attract police/security attention, or more reinforcement/barricading, especially if they are dangerous places and inexperienced people have accidents there. Preservation is another reason people try to gatekeep places, to avoid them being vandalized or burnt.

Given the feedback we have received from the UrbanX community on issues with this information being overly accessible we've decided not to publicly publish this site. We are still discussing distribution, whether there is a mandatory onboarding, site key, or we only allow this information to travel by word of mouth. Our main concern is regulating proper use of this tool and guaranteeing that users abide by our ethos.

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